

**TALES OF TERROR****VIRALGIRI
GOSWAMI, 21**

Engineer

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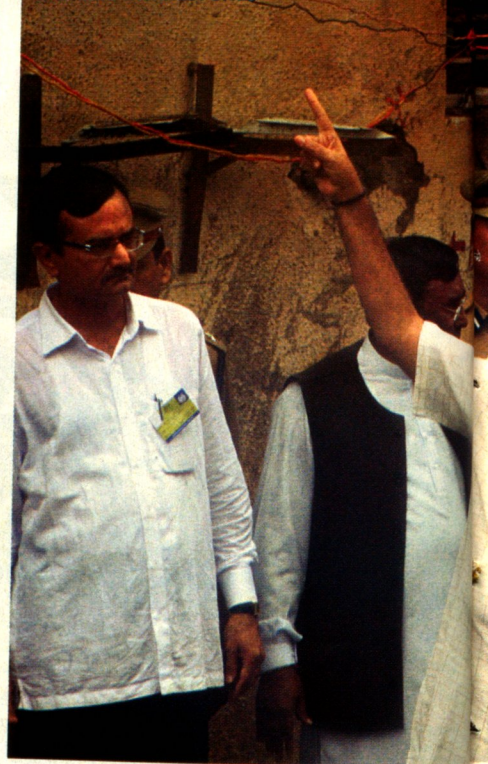
Chetan Baghora and Dhawalgiri Goswami came to the Civil Hospital to offer help to those injured in the blasts. Little did they realise that soon they would also be killed in another blast in the hospital. Standing beside Viralgiri's charred body and consoling his mother Kusum, his father Balwantgiri says, "I have no anger. I don't want to take revenge. God, please bring my son back to life."

tient from the ambulance he also sensed a spark behind him. The killer Maruti van was right behind him. He dropped to the floor, a move that saved his life. Not so fortunate was Jaikishenbhai Patel, 54, and Jashwantbhai Patel, 58, both childhood friends. Residents of Asarwa village, next to the hospital, they came to the hospital when a local BJP leader Sanjay Patel told them that the hospital needed volunteers. Sanjay escaped unhurt because he was at a distance when the blast went off but the duo died on the spot. Says Jashwantbhai's wife Annapurnaben, "They played, lived, ate and died together and their condolence meet also was organised together." Sanjay is still haunted by the fact that it was because of his urging that the two close friends had rushed to the hospital, only to lose their lives.

The case of Viralgiri Goswami, 21, an engineer who was planning to go to Australia for further studies, and his friends Chetan Baghora and Dhawalgiri Goswami, is even more haunting. All three rushed to the hospital to offer voluntary help and to donate blood but lost their own lives.

That the Ahmedabad blasts were in retaliation to the 2002 anti-Muslim riots was obvious. A majority of the blast locations were those places where Hindus had played an active role in targeting Muslims after the Godhra carnage. One bomb, which killed two people, went off near Dhanvantri Hospital, a public hospital run by a trust led by VHP General Secretary Pravin

WARNING BELLS: Narendra Modi and Manmohan Singh examine the blast sites



Togadia. Another bomb went off in Naroda village, where the pathology laboratory of a former VHP leader Jaideep Patel is located.

In Bangalore, a day earlier, the casualties were minimal but the message was equally chilling. This is the IT capital of India and the psychological fear was palpable. That is the damage that the perpetrators of terror were looking to cause. Bangalore is where it started, but almost a week after Friday's blasts, no arrests have been made, although the police have taken in several people for questioning. The reason for the blasts is still unclear but there is little doubt that the two successive terror strikes were connected. The security agencies believe that the SIMI, which has been active in south India in recent years, is behind these blasts. The Indian Mujahideen is a splinter group which broke away after SIMI was banned.

Reports suggest that Karnataka is fast emerging as south India's terror hub following a series of terror attacks. The Bangalore bombs are still something of a mystery, not because